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Oct 18, 2019

Basic Information about the Artwork¹

Name: The Archangel St. Michael

Artifact Number: 1923.06.0001

Date: Medieval, 15th century

Country of Origin: France

Materials: Plant -- Oak, Pigment -- Ink



The Archangel St. Michael (15th Century)

St. Michael: A Chivalrous Warrior in the Name of an Archangel

On the second floor of the Spurlock Museum, there quietly stands an oak made and ink-painted archangel whose name is St. Michael. However, this “archangel” has neither wings nor halos, instead, he is well equipped with meticulously forged armor and an exquisite cloak. Therefore, if you do not know his true identity in advance, you may probably mistake him for a brave and noble knight, who is holding his weapon tightly (unfortunately, the weapon is now missing and we have no idea whether he is holding a sword, a spear, or anything else), and is preoccupied with the imminent fierce battle.

This sculpture of St. Michael was made in France in the 15th century, during which the French people suffered a lot from both warfare and plague. Although misfortune claimed millions of lives, they never surrendered to invaders and diseases. As a result, the Hundred Years' War significantly awoke the French nationalism, which profoundly facilitated the

¹ Information from Spurlock Museum of World Cultures at ILLINOIS website. Retrieved 10 October 2019.
<<https://www.spurlock.illinois.edu/collections/search-collection/details.php?a=1923.06.0001>>

formation of today's France.

Now, as a visitor, when I step into the Spurlock Museum and stop in front of this historical sculpture that survived the baptism of time, gaze and meditate, I could clearly sense the message from nearly 600 years ago, that the artist who created this artifact wanted to convey to his contemporary comrades and future offspring. I feel that I could be in touch with his heart, that the theme of this sculpture is far beyond the connotation of religion, and the real protagonist is not only the archangel St. Michael, but also thousands of valiant patriots who sacrificed themselves and consecrated the land of France. These chivalrous patriots fought against invaders to protect their motherland, just like St. Michael that battled with Satan to defend heaven.

Hundreds of years have passed, when a visitor stops and appreciates this sculpture, the warrior still exudes his solemn and heroic mettle—this exactly reflects the significance of art, the resonance beyond time and space. Imagine, thousands of years ago, a crane died, our ancestors made a flute out of its bone, the octaves that the flute blew expressed the blessing of wedding, mourning of funeral, and all happiness and sadness of our forefathers. Thousands of years later, their great-great-grandchildren pick the same flute, music flows, the sympathy bridges the link between us and our ancestors, so that we are feeling the same as them—the same happiness, the same sadness, the same passion, and the same depression. Just like the flute, this sculpture of St. Michael also strikes a chord between today's generation and the French forefathers in the 15th century, such that when we see the artifact, we can clearly feel their great and unremitting struggle for liberty and freedom.